

THE

ROBOT FRAMEWORK

How I convinced a global robotics giant
to lend me a \$30K robot for free

The 5-step framework for getting anything
"out of your league"

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THE BACKSTORY

How a Random Contact Became a \$30K Robot on My Campus

Six months ago, I met someone from a robotics company during a university-organized visit to their office. We exchanged contacts on WeChat. I didn't need anything. I just saved it "just in case."

Months later, I got a crazy idea for my art engineering class: what if I used a real industrial robot in a live performance? Not a toy. Not a simulation. A real, full-size robot, performing alongside humans at Fotografiska Shanghai — one of the most well-known art spaces in the city.

Everyone told me it was impossible. Industrial robots cost tens of thousands of dollars. A company like KUKA doesn't just lend them to students. Especially not for free. Especially not to someone with zero budget and no connections.

I messaged him anyway.

He asked about my budget. I had none. He asked what kind of robot. I said whatever you have. He asked when. I had the date ready.

Three follow-ups later, an 80–90 kg industrial KUKA robot worth approximately \$30,000 arrived on my campus. I programmed it myself for the performance.

Here's the exact 5-step framework that made it happen — and how you can use it for anything.

STEP 01

Collect Contacts Before You Need Them

I met a Sales Director during a university-organized visit to a robotics company in April 2025. I wasn't looking for anything. I just added him on WeChat and moved on.

Seven months later, he had moved to KUKA — one of the world's largest industrial robotics manufacturers. That "random add" became the reason I had a \$30K industrial robot on my campus.

What happened:

■ April 2025: University visit to a robotics company. Quick intro. Added on WeChat.

■ November 2025: He had moved to KUKA. I had a crazy idea and a contact who could make it happen.

↑ *7 months between first contact and first ask. He changed companies in between. If I hadn't saved the contact, I'd never have known.*

Why this works:

- Most people only network when they need something. By then, it's too late — you're a stranger asking for a favor
- When you connect early and ask later, you're "that student from the tour" — not a cold pitch
- The contact cost me nothing. It got me access to a robot worth \$30,000 from one of the world's biggest robotics companies

The rule:

Every company visit, networking event, conference, or random introduction — save the contact. You don't need a reason right now. Your future self will thank you.

■ *Go to every campus event, company visit, and networking mixer. Exchange contacts with everyone. You have no idea which one will change your life.*

STEP 02

Pitch Their Win, Not Your Need

When I messaged him, I didn't say "can I borrow a robot?" That's a favor. Nobody owes you a favor. Instead, I pitched a collaboration that benefited both of us.

What I actually wrote:

■ You: "I'm currently preparing an art performance for our upcoming art show from NYU Shanghai, and the piece involves interactive robotics."

■ You: "The performance will take place at Fotografiska Shanghai, which is a very well-known and highly visited art space in the city. We would be happy to acknowledge your support in the exhibition materials and during the show, so it could also serve as good visibility for your service robotics work."

↑ Notice: I led with the venue (*Fotografiska*), the prestige (*well-known*), and the benefit to them (*visibility*). My need came last.

The breakdown:

- **I named the venue first.** Fotografiska Shanghai is prestigious — this immediately signals "this is real, not some dorm room project"
- **I offered them something:** Brand visibility, acknowledgment in exhibition materials. Now it's a partnership, not a handout
- **I framed it as their opportunity:** "It could serve as good visibility for your service robotics work" — I'm helping them, not the other way around

The rule:

Never ask "can you help me?" Ask "here's how we can work together." Make them the hero of the story, not the donor.

STEP 03

Reframe, Don't Retreat

This is where most people give up. He asked the question every student dreads:

■ Them: "Is there any budget for renting?"

↑ *This is the moment 99% of people disappear. They see this and think "it's over."*

I had zero budget. Literally nothing. But instead of saying "never mind" or going silent, I reframed the entire ask:

■ You: "At the moment we don't have a budget allocated for renting. Since this is a non-profit student art performance, we were hoping you might support it as an educational collaboration."

↑ *"Educational collaboration" — two words that turned a rejection into a conversation.*

Why this works:

- **I didn't lie or dodge:** I was honest about having no budget. Transparency builds trust
- **I reframed immediately:** Instead of "I can't pay," I offered "educational collaboration" — a category companies already have processes for
- **I kept the door open:** "We were hoping" is soft, respectful, and invites them to find a way — not demands one

The rule:

When someone asks a question that feels like a dead end, don't retreat. Reframe. "I can't afford it" becomes "here's what I can offer instead." The conversation isn't over until you decide it is.

STEP 04

Make It Embarrassingly Easy to Say Yes

After he showed interest, he started asking practical questions: What demo? How big? What date? This is where most pitches fall apart — people have the vision but can't answer the logistics.

Every time he had a constraint, I adapted:

■ Them: "How big is the robot you want"

■ You: "Any size is completely fine — the 40cm was just an example. We can adapt the performance concept to whatever robot you have available."

↑ *I didn't push for a specific robot. I wrapped my concept around their constraints.*

When he said they didn't have a small robot, I didn't panic. I said we'd adapt. When he asked about the demo concept, I had the theme ready (human-robot interaction) but kept it flexible enough to fit whatever they offered.

Why this works:

- **Zero friction:** I removed every possible reason for them to say no
- **Flexibility signals professionalism:** It shows you care about making it work, not just getting what you want
- **I had answers ready:** Venue ✓ Date ✓ Theme ✓ Timeline ✓ — they weren't investing in an idea, they were supporting a done deal with one missing piece

The rule:

Handle everything yourself. Logistics, planning, timeline, backup plans. Their only job should be saying yes. The easier you make it, the more likely they will.

STEP 05

Follow Up Like Your Life Depends on It

Here's the timeline of my messages:

The follow-up sequence:

- **Nov 26:** First pitch — the full proposal with venue, concept, and collaboration offer
- **Nov 27:** Follow-up — "Just checking in to see if there's any update on the robot availability. No rush at all."
- **Dec 1:** Second follow-up — "Just wanted to check in again and see if there's any update on which robot might be available."

Then:

- Them: "Yes, we have it"
- Them: "How long you need"

↑ *Three messages. Five days. That's all it took.*

Why this works:

- **Most people send one message and quit.** They interpret silence as rejection. It's usually just busyness
- **Polite persistence is not annoying.** Notice my follow-ups always included "no rush" — I was respectful, not desperate
- **Each follow-up had a reason:** Checking on availability, finalizing timeline — not just "bumping this"

The rule:

Follow up at least 3 times before assuming it's a no. Space them out (1 day, then 3–4 days). Be polite. Be specific. And never apologize for following up — it shows you're serious.

- *The fortune is in the follow-up. The people who get what they want are simply the ones who don't stop asking.*

THE RESULT

A \$30K Robot From a Global Giant, On a College Campus

Two days after the final confirmation, an 80–90 kg industrial KUKA robot worth approximately \$30,000 arrived at NYU Shanghai.

Their engineers couldn't program it for free — but I could do it myself. They didn't even know I studied engineering. That was the final piece that made the whole thing click.

I programmed the robot for a live art performance at Fotografiska Shanghai, exploring the theme of human-robot interaction. A real industrial robot, performing alongside humans, in one of the city's most visited art spaces.

All because I saved a contact, sent a message, and didn't give up after the first reply.

THE COMPLETE FRAMEWORK

The 5 Steps — Quick Reference

1 — Collect contacts before you need them

Go to every event. Save every contact. You never know which one matters.

2 — Pitch their win, not your need

Frame it as a collaboration. Lead with what they gain. Make them the hero.

3 — Reframe, don't retreat

When you hit a wall, don't disappear. Reposition the ask. The conversation isn't over until you decide it is.

4 — Make it embarrassingly easy to say yes

Handle everything. Remove friction. Their only job is saying yes.

5 — Follow up like your life depends on it

3 follow-ups minimum. Polite. Persistent. Specific. Don't stop after silence.

USE THIS FOR

How to Apply This Framework to Anything

This framework isn't just about robots. It works for any situation where you're asking someone "above your level" for something you think you shouldn't have access to.

Getting an internship

- **Step 1:** Connect with employees at target companies on LinkedIn months before applying
- **Step 2:** Don't ask "can you refer me?" — say "I built X that's relevant to your team's work on Y. I'd love to hear your perspective."
- **Step 3:** If they say the team isn't hiring, ask "Which teams are? I'm flexible on the role."
- **Step 4:** Have your portfolio, resume, and project links ready to send instantly
- **Step 5:** Follow up after 1 week and again after 2 weeks. Attach a new project or insight each time

Finding a mentor

- **Step 1:** Engage with their content for weeks before reaching out (comments, shares, thoughtful replies)
- **Step 2:** Don't ask "will you be my mentor?" — say "I'm working on X and your approach to Y changed how I think about it. Could I ask you one specific question?"
- **Step 3:** If they're too busy, ask "Is there someone you'd recommend I talk to?"
- **Step 4:** Come with a specific question, not a vague "I need guidance." Respect their time
- **Step 5:** After the conversation, follow up with what you implemented from their advice. This is how one conversation becomes a relationship

Getting a sponsorship or partnership

- **Step 1:** Build the relationship before the pitch — attend their events, engage with their brand, know their goals
- **Step 2:** Lead with audience numbers, venue prestige, or distribution — what's in it for them?
- **Step 3:** When they mention budget concerns, offer creative alternatives: logo placement, social media posts, testimonials
- **Step 4:** Have a one-pager ready: what you need, what they get, the timeline, and next steps
- **Step 5:** Follow up with a deadline: "We're finalizing partners by [date] — would love to include you"

TEMPLATES

Copy-and-Adapt Messages

Here are message templates based on exactly what worked for me. Adapt them to your situation.

The first outreach:

"Hi [Name], we connected at [event/context] a while back. I'm currently working on [project] — [1 sentence about what it is and why it matters]. I think [their company/product] would be a great fit for [specific collaboration]. Would love to explore this with you if you're open to it."

The budget reframe:

"We don't have a budget for this right now — this is a [non-profit/student/educational] project. That said, we'd love to position this as a collaboration: [specific benefit to them: visibility, acknowledgment, content, audience access]. Would this work on your end?"

The follow-up:

"Hi [Name], just checking in to see if there's any update on [specific thing you discussed]. No rush at all — I just wanted to follow up as we're [reason: finalizing plans / confirming timeline / etc.]. Thanks so much!"

■ *Notice: every template is specific, provides value, and respects their time. Never send "just following up" with no context. Always give them a reason to reply.*

The Bottom Line

The gap between "no" and "yes" is smaller than you think.
Most people never get what they want because they never ask.
Or they ask once, hear silence, and assume it's over.

Don't be most people.

Follow @1nska for build logs, frameworks, and the real story
of building a startup as a student.

Save the contact. Send the message. Follow up.
The robot is closer than you think.